she walks me through the night

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53360359.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adora is Welsh, Catra is a ballerina, 1980s, Alternate Universe - 1980s, London, Catra does burlesque on the side and it's hot, Adora has a gay awakening, Mild Hurt/Comfort, Homophobia, Internalized Homophobia, Happy Ending, Queer History, Non-Graphic Violence, Adora has parents

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English

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Part 1 of the good life

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by the_deaf_pomegranate

Summary

It's the late 1980s, and Welsh country girl Adora has found herself in a London ballet studio at the demand of her modelling agent. While she thinks she's going to gain improved posture, what she actually gets is a big crush and a massive gay awakening, thanks to ballerina and burlesque dancer Catra.

Light 1980s angst with a happy (and hopefully historically plausible) ending inspired by Sammy Rae & The Friends' awesome song 'Jackie Onassis' .

“This is what I get for listening to my agent,” Adora grumbles under her breath, “Improve your posture, my arse.”

“Nothing wrong with your arse,” Adora startles as a playful voice seeps into her ear and she feels the bristle of another woman’s hair on her shoulder, “Posture is another story, though.”

Adora can only gape open-mouthed as she watches a slight brunette saunter past her and work her way to the very front of the class. It’s impossible to look away from her smooth complexion and dark brown waves - Adora thinks her hair might be natural, not even a blow-out - but when the woman starts to stretch, her leg propped high on the barre, heat prickles inexplicably across Adora’s chest.

Notes

I've been reading a lot and listening to a lot of music while waiting for my lung scarring to heal up after a bad winter

infection all month, and the combination of 80s literature and an excellent Spotify playlist got this concept stuck in my head! Not sure where the Welsh angle came from, but idk, it just felt good. It's a little different from most my fics - and is my first historical one - but I hope you enjoy it nonetheless.

Please note there are some homophobic slurs included in the dialogue.

As always, hugely grateful for any kudos or comments you have to share!

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora Grey didn’t think she’d find herself in ballet class at the age of twenty, but it’s August 1987 and that’s exactly where she is.

The room is filling up with young women just like her, presumably aspiring actors and dancers. Everywhere she looks, there’s someone with a better perm than her or a brighter smile. She’s used to comparing herself to others after three years of go-sees and ad auditions - there’s a lot of tall, blonde ingenues in the London fashion scene - but Adora feels a little more self conscious than usual as everyone filters in. It’s supposed to be a beginners’ class, yet she’s pretty sure she’s the only student who’s never set foot in a dance studio before. The more discomfort creeps slowly up her spine, the harder it becomes to ignore the itch of her pale tights and black lycra leotard.

There’s only one thing for it. Adora bends down to her duffel bag and pulls out a tube of Carmex, staring in the mirror as she runs it over her lips. The studio lights bounce off the curves of her glossed fake smile and for a quick second, it makes her feel like she could take on anything.

Still, she has to stop herself from snorting at her reflection when she remembers her younger self’s aversion to make-up. She'd always been a tomboy growing up and Adora’s sure if she hadn’t been scouted during a trip to Cardiff at seventeen, she’d be working with her brother on the family farm. It’s pointless thinking too hard about it - her life’s a million miles away from the Welsh countryside now.

When the chatter surrounding her dies down, Adora turns to find the instructor at the front of the room. He has a severe expression, clearly a disciple of the tough love method, and Adora’s gut immediately flips. She can already tell that she’s going to bear the brunt of his frustration thanks to her two left feet.

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"Nothing wrong with your arse," Adora startles as a playful voice seeps into her ear and she feels the bristle of another woman's hair on her shoulder, "Posture *is* another story, though."

Adora can only gape open-mouthed as she watches a slight brunette saunter past her and work her way to the very front of the class. It's impossible to look away from her smooth complexion and dark brown waves - Adora thinks her hair might be natural, not even a blow-out - but when the woman starts to stretch, her leg propped high on the barre, heat prickles inexplicably across Adora's chest.

She can't be a beginner, she thinks, trying not to let her staring seem obvious, *she looks like she's danced all her life!*

"This is Mademoiselle Horde," the instructor announces in a thick Russian accent, and the brunette curtsies to all of them, "A former pupil of mine, awaiting rehearsals for her next tour. She will assist me in making corrections."

"I knew it!" Adora punches the air, though she clamps her hands over her mouth as soon as others turn to look at her. She did *not* mean to say that out loud.

"Sorry," Adora mutters. *Of course*, she's embarrassed herself before the lesson even begins.

"You can call me Catra," the brunette speaks over Adora, commanding everyone's attention back to the front. Adora doesn't miss the quirk of her upper lip when their eyes briefly meet - she's clearly holding back a giggle.

Great. Everyone thinks I'm an idiot now.

She spends most of the lesson trying to fade into the background as much as possible. It's a hard task, given that everyone else seems to know the basic first to fifth positions already, and Adora never even got the hang of the Electric Slide. The first time Catra walks past and inspects her form, Adora feels like the dancer's scrutiny conducts heat on her skin. It's nerve-wracking, like being

inspected by a casting director, but she's also strangely excited. Her need to impress doesn't feel competitive like it normally does yet there's something that makes Adora yearn for Catra's approval. She clearly doesn't get it - after the hundredth time Catra has to correct the point of her toes and the angle of her wrist, Adora's convinced she's destined to die of awkwardness.

When the class finally finishes, Adora's determined to leave and never return. She hurries to collect her bag and shucks her denim jacket over her leotard. She's got no desire to prolong her presence at the studio by getting properly dressed.

"Hey!" Catra's voice cuts over her classmates' chatter as Adora makes to leave, "Aren't you forgetting something?"

"Umm," Adora cringes, waiting as Catra jogs over to her, "I paid at reception before class started."

"Not that, dummy," Catra smirks and Adora sees that her eyes aren't just heterochromatic; at such close range, she can see tiny flecks of gold in both her blue and amber eyes.

"What?"

"You're still wearing your ballet pumps," Catra runs her hand up Adora's arm and it erupts into goosebumps, "Slow down a little."

Adora tries to laugh it off and returns to where she'd left her shoes at the edge of the room. Catra follows her, zipping a denim boilersuit over her leotard and shoving her feet into heeled ankle boots with a degree of grace that Adora has never seen before.

"What's your story then?" Catra asks before Adora can attempt escape again, "You don't sound like you're from here."

Adora chuckles, pinning a permed curl behind her ear, "I'm from Llangynidr. I've been in London for three years though. My agent made me move here."

“Your agent?” Catra cocks her head. For absolutely no reason, Adora wants to touch the plane of skin connecting her jaw to her shoulder. She wonders if Catra’s skin would tingle like hers did.

“I’m a model. Or trying to be,” Adora confesses.

Catra drags her eyes up and down Adora’s body, and if Adora didn’t know better, she’d think Catra’s teeth bit down a little on the corner of her lip.

“Interesting. You’ve got more muscle than most models I’ve seen, princess.”

“I work at Bright Moon Video Rental most of the time,” Adora hurries to clarify, “The little purple shop round the corner? I kinda just sit there watching the returns and wait for customers to come in.”

Catra raises her eyebrow impossibly high. “You work at a video shop in Soho?”

“Oh!” Adora’s eyes widen, realising that most people visit Soho to find a very specific kind of video. She’s basically just told Catra she spends her day watching perverse smut, and Adora is *not* that kind of girl, thank you very much, “It’s not like that! I mainly watch *Alien* on repeat.”

She waits for Catra to acknowledge the misunderstanding and agree that Adora’s day job is quite normal after all.

“Have you seen it yet?” Adora tries to evoke a response, “You really should. Sigourney Weaver’s fantastic in it!”

Adora’s voice echoes on the polished floors, still unanswered. Catra’s lips curve into a smirk, a dimple creasing into her left cheek. She plays with the metal tab of her zip, drawing Adora’s eye right into her cleavage. Not that Adora means to look, it’s totally an accident.

“So you do like brunettes in boilersuits then?” Catra asks, though it sounds more like a statement.

There’s no time for Adora to figure out her point; Catra pushes oversized sunglasses onto her face and saunters away before she has any opportunity. Suddenly, Adora notices that everyone else has already left the studio. It’s a blessing - when she catches sight of herself in the mirror, she’s flushed scarlet.

What the hell just happened?

Adora doesn’t know what to do with herself. No woman has ever looked at her - or spoken to her - the way Catra Horde just did, and she’s utterly bewildered.

Adora can’t bring herself to return to the ballet studio but she shuffles her stool a little closer to the till so she can be seen through the shop window. Every day for a week, she’s hoped Catra might come in to say hello. She’s seen her through the window on her way to class a couple of times but so far, no luck.

She presses play on the television in the corner and leans forward to rest her elbows on the counter.

“Not this again,” Glimmer groans, letting the shop door swing shut as she wanders back in from her break, “Adora, you must have played this a million times by now. What gives?”

“It’s a good film,” Adora doesn’t acknowledge Bow’s contribution when he comes onto the shop floor after spending the past ten minutes checking the back room stock. Even out the corner of her eye, Adora can tell his clothes are almost as dishevelled as Glimmer’s hair. She doesn’t know who they’re trying to kid.

"Sigourney Weaver's fantastic in it," Adora states, a little more conviction in her voice now that she knows - well, assumes - that Catra agrees, "If you actually paid attention, you'd probably get a lot more out of it."

Glimmer plonks herself down on the stool next to Adora. "If you say so. But for God's sake, can we please just watch something else today?"

"Fine," Adora gives in, pulling a tape out from under the counter and handing it to Bow so he can replace the one in the video player, "*Flashdance* got returned this morning."

"My favourite!" Bow lights up, and Adora wouldn't have been surprised if he started clapping.

Glimmer is stupidly obvious - she gazes at him with stars in her eyes that sparkle almost as much as the body glitter dabbed on her cheekbones. Her friends had grown up in the shop together, spending their weekends covering shifts to save extra cash for concerts and new clothes. Ever since she started at Bright Moon, Adora felt a little like a third wheel, though it's only been in the past few months that something seems to have shifted significantly between them. Now Adora's often left alone when Glimmer and Bow make thinly-veiled excuses to sneak out and fool around. She's certain they're the worst secret-keepers she's ever come across - they'd get found out in seconds if they lived in her little Welsh town. Watching the way they look at each other makes Adora laugh to think they call *her* the delusionally romantic one; that they've teased her for turning down a string of guys whose kisses didn't make butterflies somersault in her stomach.

Bow squeals as Jennifer Beale cycles to her job at the steel mill on their tiny monitor. Adora wishes they could skip ahead to the audition dance at the end already. She can imagine Catra doing that routine, black leg warmers squished round her ankles. She bets Catra could do it even better than in the movie. She's a real dancer after all. No-one would be able to take their eyes off her right from the second she started moving.

Glimmer elbows Adora in the side, jerking her out of her daydream. She hears the shop door ring as it closes shut behind a couple of women.

"Look, customers," Glimmer mutters, stepping back from the counter to make it clear that she's absolutely not getting distracted from the film.

Adora sighs, turning her head to survey the shop floor. She thinks she must be going crazy - one of the newcomers is rifling through the video cases on the opposite wall, and from behind, Adora thinks she looks exactly like Catra.

Am I going crazy? Why do I think about her so often?

She nearly chokes when the customer makes her way to the service counter. It *is* Catra, wearing a boxy skirt suit short enough to see a glimpse of her suspenders when she walks.

"Overalls and leotards. Tracks you'd like *Flashdance* too," Catra smirks, sliding the empty case of her chosen video tape towards Adora. Her fingernails are cut short like a man's despite being painted in the glossiest red. It's terribly confusing - Adora's never seen such a pointless, perfect manicure in her life.

Adora scrambles to find the video Catra wants. It's *My Beautiful Laundrette.* She's never watched it but Bow told her once that it's got gay sex in it. Adora doesn't know why Catra would be interested in a film like that. She wonders if it's a local thing, if Catra likes supporting British films instead of the big American blockbusters that most people watch.

"Have you seen it?" Catra asks her, "I've heard it's good, but I'd be more confident if it had your recommendation."

"I… I haven't seen it," Adora stammers as she fumbles to put the VHS in the plastic box, "Not for any particular reason or anything, I just haven't gotten round to it."

“Relax,” Catra smiles at her, grazing Adora’s hand with her fingers when she picks up the video case, “I didn’t mean anything by it.”

“Oh, okay. Tidy,” Adora blushes but she doesn’t get a chance to recover from her blunder before the other customer sidles over and jams her arm through Catra’s.

“Have you got it, Wildcat?” This woman’s even taller than Adora, her cropped hair bleached a shocking white.

“Yup.” Catra doesn’t take her eyes off Adora when she answers, “Just talking to my friend here.”

Adora’s heart warms when Catra says they’re friends, though she doesn’t think Catra even knows her name.

“Adora,” she juts her hand out towards Catra’s companion so she can be introduced without making a fool of her apparent new friend, “Lush to meet you, it is.”

“I’m Scorpia! It’s lovely to meet you,” the woman responds enthusiastically, shaking Adora’s hand with vim before she leans closer to Catra, “Is this the Welsh girl you told me about? You should invite her to the show!”

Catra seems to blush when Adora looks back at her, in a shocking reversal of roles. Has Catra been telling other people about her?

“Yes,” Catra says with clearly feigned confidence, as if she’d always known her name, “Adora is a one-time pupil of mine.”

“Pupil?” Adora laughs despite herself, “I didn’t realise you could promote yourself to instructor!”

“Funny. I didn’t realise anyone could ever need as many corrections as you did,” Catra studies Adora again with a wry smile, raking her eyes over the cropped *Wham!* t-shirt she’d borrowed from Bow, “Maybe you *should* come to the show. You might learn something.”

Adora gulps, waiting for more information. Her exposed abs suddenly feel very cold now they're visible to someone as impressive as Catra.

“Thursday night at the Crimson Waste, ten o’clock. Scorpia’s singing,” Catra says curtly, before glancing at Glimmer and leaning in to whisper in Adora’s ear, “Don’t bring the glittery freakazoid with you.”

“I heard that!” Glimmer yells after them as they leave, but Catra only puts her sunglasses on and giggles in response. It’s a high-pitched peal of laughter that Adora thinks she can feel flow through the core of her soul, like a waterfall trickling over her.

“Eat my shorts, Sparkles!”

“What an asshole,” Glimmer mutters when the door slams shut behind Catra and Scorpia, crossing her arms across her chest, “You can’t go to that Crimson Wave, or whatever it’s called. I’ve never even heard of it! It can’t be decent.”

Adora shrugs, leaning back to watch the TV again. “As if, I’m too much of a twp for that. Got a go-see on Friday morning anyway.”

“Better get that beauty sleep in, ‘Dor,” Glimmer snuggles into Adora’s side, beckoning Bow over to join them for a group hug, “You’re only one yes away from your big break!”

Adora grins, swallowed by the warmth of her friends’ embrace. Still, it doesn’t stop her pulse racing a little when she thinks about Catra’s invitation. Ten o’clock at the Crimson Waste is already burned into her brain.

Adora’s lucky Catra invited her with a few days’ notice - it takes her until Thursday lunch to figure out where the Crimson Waste

even is.

She'd spent hours trying to decide what to wear, unsure what kind of dress code a place that Catra likes would have. In the end, Adora had settled on a black corset top and leather trousers under her denim jacket, just like Madonna at the AMAs. She's convinced no-one could take offence at it. Everyone loves Madonna.

Adora squints at the Crimson Waste from across the road. She's never really been out on her own this late in London before (especially not on a weekday), and Adora wonders if she's made a terrible mistake by not telling anyone. Still, the closer she gets, the more Adora notices that almost everyone seems to approach the venue alone, looking around furtively before they enter. It gives Adora the courage to scurry through the traffic and rush up to the bouncer before she can lose her mettle.

"Is this the Crimson Waste?" Adora jams her hands in her pockets as she leans into the personal space of a tall, incredibly muscular woman with a shaved scalp and a long ponytail, "Catra Horde invited me but I dunno if I got the right place, if I'm honest! She didn't give me the address."

The bouncer snorts, tipping her head towards the entry door and signalling for Adora to go in. "Not often our kitty-cat gives anyone her real name."

Adora wants to question the bouncer but she's ushered inside quickly; a queue's starting to build up outside the building, and Adora's got the feeling people don't like to hang about. She makes her way down a dimly lit flight of uncarpeted stairs, nerves rising up her spine. There's muffled noise coming from behind a set of black velvet drapes at the bottom, a tiny crack of golden light seeping through.

It's impossible not to gasp when she finally slips through the curtains.

Adora doesn't know where to look first: the tulle canopies pinned to the ceilings; round chestnut tables littered with candles in jars; cigarette smoke rising to the ceiling and casting a fog around a small stage by the far wall. She ambles over to the bar and points at a colourful cocktail the bartender is serving up, asking for the same. Adora has no idea what's in it, but when the coral liquid sweeps over her tongue it spreads warmth through her entire body.

"Haven't seen you here before, sweetheart," the bartender has a serious sounding voice that doesn't quite match with her willowy body and waist-length golden hair, "Come to watch the show?"

She nods, only just noticing that she can't see a single man around. There's people who are dressed like men, sure. But instead of stubbly jaws, Adora only sees smooth, buttery cheeks.

Adora leans over the bar and speaks quietly so no-one can overhear. "Not to be stupid or anything, but is this place…?"

"A lesbian bar? You got it," Adora blushes at the confirmation before the bartender continues proudly, pointing towards the stage, "Look, they're starting! My girlfriend's coming on first."

Girlfriend?

Adora follows the direction of her finger and swivels on her barstool to face the stage. Her gut flips with excitement when she recognises Scorpia dressed up to the nines. When she starts singing, Adora's taken aback by how good she is. She didn't know lesbians could sound so gentle and feminine, or that they'd want to sing *Running Up That Hill* by Kate Bush. It is about God, after all. Or, at least, she'd thought it was.

After Scorpia finishes, there's a woman telling jokes that Adora doesn't really get but laughs at when everyone else does, followed by another much older singer who takes on Diana Ross' *I'm Coming Out.* Everyone gets so enthusiastic about the song choice that it's hard not to get swept up with the energy in the

room. Still, Adora itches waiting to see Catra. With every act, she becomes more desperate to uncover what Catra's going to do in hers. By the time her wristwatch ticks past eleven-thirty, she's hardly sure Catra's slated to perform at all.

It's nearly midnight when the bouncer appears next to Adora at the bar and nudges her shoulder. "Ready to get for what you came for, blondie?"

Adora's about to turn around and respond when all the lights turn off, casting the bar into pitch darkness. She starts to panic, wondering if something's gone terribly wrong, when a sultry track begins to play.

🎶 *Never know how much I love you, never know how much I care* 🎶

A singular spotlight shines a white circle on the stage. Catra's sitting backwards on a spindly chair in a silk dressing gown, her thighs set either side of the seat as her left wrist twists in circles and clicks on the beat.

🎶 *When you put your arms around me, I get a fever that's so hard to bear. You give me fever* 🎶

The entire audience starts to click their fingers in time with her. Catra shimmies the robe down her right shoulder as she turns to face them, and Adora's breath is stolen away when Catra seems to find her in the darkness, winking right at her as she reveals the lacy cup of her bra.

Catra's hands stroke a line from her gullet to her bellybutton, grazing between her breasts and past her bra underwire until they snap back up to her lips, a single gloved finger trapped between her teeth. She teases the elbow-length glove off until it dangles from her mouth; and suddenly she's turned her back to the audience and dropped the dressing gown entirely.

🎶 When you kiss me, fever when you hold me tight. Fever! In the mornin', a-fever all through the night 🎶

Catra fans herself, batting her eyelashes at the crowd as she removes her other glove.

She drops so seamlessly into the splits that Adora's jaw falls open. By all accounts, she isn't alone - a shiver seems to ripple through the space as everyone marvels at her flexibility. Catra revels in the attention, a coy smile spreading across her face. She walks her fingers down her leg to the beat until she's bent flat, licking her own thigh slowly and undoing a suspender clip with her teeth. The room erupts in whoops as she whips around and curls her front leg under her, pointing her other foot in a straight line to the ceiling so she can undo the suspender clips on that thigh too.

🎶 Chicks were born to give you fever, be it fahrenheit or centigrade. They give you fever 🎶

When Catra ascends to her feet and circles the chair, unzipping her suspender belt to reveal more of her miniscule thong, Adora can hardly feel anything past the loud thrum of blood pounding in her ears. She doesn't know what she should look at - *where* she's supposed to focus her attention - when there's so much she's simply dying to see.

🎶 When you kiss them, fever if you live and learn… Fever! 'Til you sizzle 🎶

Catra sits down again, the chair back partially obscuring her torso, and unclasps her bra. Twirling both legs to one side and dipping her head back further than seems humanly possible, she seems to defy gravity. Adora can see every second of Catra's ballet training in the extraordinary control she has extending her body in a straight line. Her hair grazes the floor as she stretches her arm out past her head, swinging her lingerie off the ends of her fingers.

🎶 What a lovely way to burn… 🎶

The last thing Adora sees before the lights black out again is a satisfied smile spreading across Catra's face.

Unbeknownst to anyone else, Adora finds herself back at the Crimson Waste the following Thursday night. She'd waited all week to bump into Catra and tell her how incredible her performance was, but Catra's been MIA since she disappeared from the stage.

"Good to see you again, blondie," the bouncer ushers her into the bar straightaway, "Tell kitty-cat 'hi' from me if you find her."

Adora stations herself in the same spot at the bar and waits for the show to begin. This time, she notices how other women glance at her from across the room, and how their eyes drag up the toned length of her exposed arms. She expects to feel uncomfortable - that's always been her experience when men check her out on the dancefloor - but the prickling in her gut doesn't seem unpleasant. Instead, Adora feels like her power grows with every appreciative nod, even if she declines the drinks offered to her.

"You're getting comfortable there, princess," a familiar voice rolls over her skin, "Came back for more?"

Adora's head snaps up to find Catra slithering onto the barstool next to her. She's wearing her denim boiler suit again, unzipped to the navel to display a neon yellow bra.

"You're not performing tonight? You were amazing last week!" Adora gushes.

Catra grins, though she tries to hide it.

“Can’t give away the goods every time,” she jokes, “There’s far too many pining women and not enough lesbian burlesque dancers for that.”

“So you are, then?” Adora asks carefully, her eyes flitting back and forth nervously between Catra’s face and the floor, “A lesbian?”

Catra leans in close and gazes into Adora’s eyes. The strength of her attention forces Adora not to look away.

“What about me possibly suggests that I’m not?”

Adora’s taken aback by Catra’s surety of herself. She can’t imagine being so brash about something like this.

“Well,” she says slowly, “You’re my first one. Lesbian, I mean. I don’t know what… How people like that are.”

“Hmmm. I think if you’d figure it out quite easily if you tried,” Catra says, tugging Adora to her feet, “Come out for a couple of hours. Promise I’ll show you a good time.”

Adora lets Catra pull her through the velvet curtains and up the stairs. A thrill runs through her when they meet the night sky and Catra doesn’t let go of her hand. She’s so focused on Catra’s close proximity - how her freckles seem to dance in the moonlight and her long hair swishes in the inky breeze - that she hardly notices her surroundings until they’re back in their home corner of Soho.

Catra fishes a set of keys out of her purse as they reach the ballet studio and when she lets go of Adora’s hand to open the door, Adora's palm feels unprecedentedly cold. Yet her newfound solitude doesn’t last long. Catra pulls Adora into the building and shuts the door behind them quickly, pressing her against the wall with urgency.

Adora doesn’t know where the instinct comes from but she knows that she has to touch Catra. She’s never felt so compelled to do anything before, like her body has no choice but to respond to the magnetism that draws them closer. She wonders how many

people have grasped Catra's curves before she has - *how many women* - but it’s hard to believe that anyone else could truly understand the intuition that’s pulling her in.

They stare at each other, chests heaving, and adrenaline rushes even faster through Adora’s veins. She doesn’t notice that she’s leaning in until Catra’s whisper ghosts her skin, their lips only millimetres apart.

“You haven’t done this before, have you?”

“I’m not a virgin,” Adora balks, “I’ve had three boyfriends.”

“That’s not what I meant,” Catra drags a finger up Adora’s arm and goosebumps erupt in her wake, “You’ve never kissed a woman.”

For the first time in her life, Adora doesn’t feel the need to think anything through. She cups Catra’s chin with both hands and closes the distance between them.

“Quick, get up,” Adora rouses to the sound of Catra’s harried voice, groaning as she feels her bones creak on the hard studio floor, “The early classes will come in.”

She lets Catra hoist her to her feet, startling when she sees the brunette’s exposed decolletage and the dark, purpling bruises littered up the side of her neck. Catra zips her boilersuit up to the top - Adora’s surprised to feel disappointment surge inside her - and rushes to the mirrored wall, licking the pads of her fingertips and dragging them across her face to neaten what’s left of her make-up. Adora’s hands feel cold with nothing under them.

“Catra,” Adora half says, half breathes, “Come back.”

Catra rolls her eyes playfully. “Why don’t you come here, princess? You could do with some cleaning up yourself.”

Adora ducks her head and ambles over. She lets Catra rub at her face, though the other woman eventually sighs in defeat and shoves her sunglasses on Adora’s face to hide her badly smudged eyeliner. Adora swells proudly at the knowledge that Catra trusts her enough to let her borrow her statement sunglasses. Catra groans at the tangles that have knotted in her hair, and Adora wishes she had the confidence to drag her away from the mirror and pull her back to the floor. She’s desperate to taste Catra’s cherry-red lips and lick the inside of her mouth again.

“I’ve got a spare leotard to wear in the closet but you’ll have to leave,” Catra distracts Adora from her lust, “I can’t get caught at work.”

“Can I see you again?” Adora asks. She sounds a little more eager than she means to, though it makes Catra smile a little.

“Maybe,” Catra answers, teetering on her tiptoes to press their lips together briefly. It’s only a peck, but more pleasure rushes through Adora than entire hours of sex have granted her in the past, “If you think you’re up to it.”

“Why wouldn’t I be up to it?” Adora questions. She’s almost offended, her chest twisting with confusion.

“You’re not the first ‘straight girl’ I’ve had a bit of fun with,” Catra sighs deeply, her fingers drawing exclamation marks around her accusation, “But I’m no-one’s dirty plaything.”

“‘Straight girl’? What else am I?”

“Don’t play dumb, princess. Do us both a favour and figure out what you’re doing.”

Adora wants to object but she knows Catra is right. Good girls don’t do things like what she wants to do to Catra, things she never wanted to do to any of her boyfriends before. She’s seen

the adverts on TV of young men meeting early graves, and news articles about sterile hospital rooms that no-one wants to enter. That isn't the future she imagined for herself, or that her family might want for her. A tremble passes through Adora and Catra notices.

"You best get going," Catra doesn't meet Adora's eyes again. It leaves her devastatingly speechless, totally incapable of finding appropriate words to say.

There's little she can do except leave, especially once the sound of dancers arriving for their lessons starts to echo down the corridors. Adora shimmies out the studio window Catra points her to and lands in the alleyway, grateful that it's already bright enough to see down the narrow road clearly.

She tries to be as quiet as possible when she lets herself into the flat she shares with Glimmer and Bow above the video shop, but her stealthiness turns out to be moot when she finds her flatmates eating breakfast at the kitchen counter.

"Are you okay?" Bow asks, dropping his spoon into his cereal bowl, his eyes wide with concern.

"What? I'm fine," Adora's suddenly irritable, the sting of Catra's rejection sinking into her skin. She takes off Catra's sunglasses and hides them in her palms, "Why are you up this early anyway?"

"You're being weird," Glimmer says, crossing her arms, "Where did you go last night? We heard you sneaking out."

"Surprised you noticed," Adora retorts bitterly, "Did you not distract each other enough?"

Bow and Glimmer look at each other, their expressions a mix of guilt and surprise. It diverts their attention long enough for Adora to stalk past them and rush to her room, slamming the door shut behind her and placing the sunglasses gently on her bedside table. She sinks onto her bed and stares up at the ceiling.

Why do I feel like this?

Adora pulls her dress to her nose, searching for any remnant of Catra's perfume on the fabric, but there's nothing. Inexplicably, a tear squeezes from her eye and rolls back onto her pillow. The idea that she'll never see Catra again seems to physically hurt. But how can she possibly allow herself to? She certainly isn't *gay* - no one from her little village is - and Adora doesn't think she's anything like the curious women she found at the Crimson Waste.

"No," she tells herself, her voice a soundless murmur, "It doesn't make any sense."

Except Adora wishes she could kiss up Catra's arm until she reaches her jaw, and that she could spend forever running her hands up Catra's thighs. She wants to lie on top of Catra and shield her from the whole of London for safekeeping. Nothing can save Adora but watching Catra dance and undoing the brunette's suspender clips for her with her own teeth.

Lesbian or not, she's got to find a way of having Catra again.

It takes another three Thursdays for Adora to build up the confidence to go back to the Crimson Waste. She'd spent so much time gazing out of the shop window, hoping to catch a familiar flash of brown hair, that she'd missed multiple calls from her agent while sitting right next to the phone. Soon the truth becomes undeniable. Adora spends too much of her time thinking about kissing Catra to let her go - if that makes her gay, so be it.

Adora settles herself back on the same stool she'd chosen on her past two visits. This time, the bartender grasps her hand and sends her a blinding smile. She's wearing a flower crown and a seventies-style floaty dress. It's hugely outdated and Adora isn't certain if that's an intentional choice.

“Adora, is it? So wonderful to see you here again, Scorp and I weren’t sure if you’d come back!”

“Y-yeah,” Adora responds unsurely. Despite her revelation, she isn’t sure if being well known in these circles is a good thing, “Here I am.”

“Oh! There I go putting you on the back foot! I’m Perfuma. We were so pleased Kitty brought a new friend to the Waste.”

“Kitty? Is that Catra’s nickname?” Adora finally jumps on the opportunity to ask, lowering her voice to a whisper just in case.

“It’s her stage name, darling. Kitty Bomb. Best not say her real name too loudly. She can get a lot of unwanted attention from our more *enthusiastic* patrons, if you know what I mean. But Kitty’s rarely ever interested.”

Adora nods. She can imagine Catra’s popularity easily. Nevertheless, a little kernel of joy blooms inside her at the thought that Catra might have seen something special in her.

“Is she here?”

“She will be in a second,” Perfuma nods sagely at the stage, “Your girl’s the first up tonight.”

Adora might have been prepared for Kitty Bomb this time, but she’s far less prepared for the hopeful heat that floods her when Perfuma’s words sink in.

When ‘*her girl’* takes to the stage, Adora marvels at the way Catra teases the audience with feather fans, contorting into impossible positions as she slowly conceals and reveals her body. Every arch of Catra’s spine reminds her of grasping the dancer’s slender waist in her hand, and what Catra’s flushed skin tasted like under her tongue. All she can think about is when she'll inhale Catra’s perfume again, if she manages to play her cards right.

“Go and tell her how much you liked it,” Perfuma says with a wink when Adora stares at the stage for a little too long after Catra’s disappeared from sight, “If you knock four times on the dressing room door, they’ll know I sent you.”

It takes Adora an embarrassing amount of time to find her way backstage and locate the dressing room despite Perfuma’s detailed directions. When she finally stands in front of the door, she can hear Catra’s laughter on the other side; for all her nerves, Adora knows she wants to hear it for herself, not just second-hand. She knocks four times with more confidence than she feels.

“‘Fuma?” Scorpia opens the door excitedly, her smile only falling for a split second when she sees it’s Adora there, “Oh, Adora! Great to see you!”

“Perfuma sent me,” Adora explains, slinking into the tiny shoebox room when Scorpia steps aside. She tries to catch Catra’s eye but she’s reapplying her lipstick, replacing the forgotten pillarbox red of her performance make up with a vibrant fuschia that matches her skin-tight vest.

“Does she need me?” Scorpia’s enthusiasm ripples through the room, “I can help at the bar if she’s short of a hand.”

“No, no. She said… Well, actually. I just wanted to see Catra.”

That makes Catra look up - she turns around in her seat and leans back on the edge of the dressing table, smacking her lips together to press the tint in. Adora can see a glint in her eye. Catra is intrigued, which given how their last encounter ended, is more than she expected.

“Give us the room, yeah?” Catra says, her focus not drifting from Adora for a second.

Scorpia sidles out and then there’s enough room for Adora to breathe. Not that she really can when Catra’s this close.

“So…” Catra continues, her foot dangling dangerously close to Adora’s calf, “You got something you wanna say?”

“Not much. Just that I figured it out,” Adora replies and steps forward, leaning down so that her hair tickles Catra’s shoulder. She waits for Catra’s jaw to tilt up - to feel her breath on her skin - and hopes she hasn’t misjudged the whole thing. She’s never felt so scared and so brave at the same time.

“And what’s that mean, princess?” Catra’s voice is low and sultry, not much louder than whisper. Adora’s close enough that it sounds like pretty thunder.

Adora kisses Catra without hesitation. Her hand rises of its own accord to Catra’s neck, drawing her in impossibly closer.

“I’m not a straight girl,” Adora murmurs, hardly a hair’s breadth between them, and her pulse spikes a little at saying her confession out loud for the first time, “I’m a Catra girl… And maybe a Sigourney girl too.”

Catra seemingly grows in confidence when she hears those words; she fixes her hand to Adora’s nape and scratches at the base of her scalp. Adora leans deeper into her embrace, revelling in the satisfying scrape of blunt nails under her hair. Kissing Catra is even more intoxicating than she remembers. Adora feels like the entire building could be burning down and she’d still struggle to stop for long enough to leave this little dressing room.

“I gotta hit the road,” Catra says against Adora’s lips a little breathlessly, “You coming?”

Adora nods, stealing another kiss. Catra laughs, placing her hand on Adora’s sternum. Her touch is soft yet firm, defying the eagerness with which Catra chases Adora’s lips for one last peck. She stands, looking up at Adora when they’ve reached full height, and smudges the pad of her thumb against Adora’s lip.

“You’ll have to wear my lippy. It’s too obvious otherwise.”

She guides Adora to perch on the dressing table, nudging her knees apart so she can fit between Adora's thighs. Catra leans forward - almost as close as when they were kissing - and takes the lid off the thin gold lipstick case, her eyes never leaving Adora's mouth as she twists the lipstick up. She slides the colour across Adora's lips with practised expertise.

"Beautiful," she says, and something inside Adora melts. She's been called beautiful a million times by agents and boys and casting directors, but hearing the compliment has never made her feel like this before.

She follows Catra out of the dressing room and through the bar in a daze, squeezing the slender hand that leads her. It seems like the entire Crimson Waste fixates on them as soon as they appear, all attention sucked away from the drag king on stage.

"Where you running off to with the newbie, Kitty? Not sticking around for a drink?" A broad, handsome woman with a shaved scalp calls out to them as they cut through the tables.

Catra pauses and tugs on Adora's hands, weaving them towards her. She takes the lit cigarette out of the woman's mouth and draws it to her own instead, a waft of smoke unfurling when she exhales. "Why? Are you jealous?"

Adora steps closer to Catra, her feet moving of their own accord. She suddenly feels defensive, territorial. Her hand wraps around Catra's hip.

"Relax, princess," Catra leans her head back to rest on Adora's shoulder, her lips rolling towards Adora's ear, "I'm pretty sure she's jealous of me. Everyone loves a bit of fresh meat."

Adora blushes, more conscious than ever of the many eyes on them. She can feel the heat of the room's attention, and the brush of Catra's shoulder against her breast does little to assuage her self-consciousness.

Thankfully, Catra's possessive voice bleeds into the air just before she drops off a mental cliff, "Too bad you're all mine."

There's a nibble on her lobe and Adora can't believe Catra's doing this in front of everyone; that she's being claimed by a woman like this in public. Her shackles rise, panic rising in her chest, and then… Then Adora remembers that there's nothing she has to focus on but Catra's perfume in the Crimson Waste. The only thing she has to worry about here is how deeply her earlobe is going to be stained pink when Catra's done.

Right as Adora starts to get comfortable, Catra cackles and pulls Adora away, knocking into her once they're at the top of the stairs.

"You should know that I'll be thinking of kissing you the whole way home," Catra tells her, "Imagine it's me running my hands through your hair when the wind whips through it."

"Yeah," Adora grins breathlessly, "Me too."

They break apart when they step into the street, but Adora can't complain at the sight of Catra striding ahead of her. She carries herself so right, and Adora knows she's enjoying herself when she starts to sing under her breath. It's the same song she'd performed to earlier, but Adora doesn't know what it is or who it's by. She doesn't care to know. As long as Catra keeps singing it, she'll listen.

It only takes a few weeks for their post-performance walks to become routine.

"Head's up, freakazoid, I'm coming in!"

Adora shrieks as Glimmer barrels through her bedroom door. She was sure her flatmates wouldn't be up yet. It's hours before they usually stumble into the kitchen for Saturday breakfast, pretending they haven't spent the entire night fucking. This time, at least, they're not the only ones having fun. Catra had appeared in the doorway of the shop as Adora was locking up after her shift last night, and Adora couldn't quite bear to let her leave.

She can practically see everything happen in slow motion: Glimmer's eyes jumping from Adora's nakedness under the covers; empty beer bottles rolling from the doorway and crashing into the bedposts; purpling love bites blooming on Catra's abdomen as she sits in her turquoise lingerie next to Adora atop the duvet, her fingers tangled in the ends of blonde hair.

Catra flinches almost as hard as Adora when she looks up at Glimmer, instantly pulling her knees up to hide her torso. Adora hardly knows what to do. She knows she must be a sight; there's probably lipstick stains from Catra's old make-up smeared on her lips and neck.

"Adora?" Glimmer looks uncertain, quiet for the first time in years, "What's going on?"

Catra stills next to Adora. It feels like they're in space, like all the oxygen available has disappeared.

"Exactly what it looks like," Adora says finally, her words sinking like quicksand on her tongue, "Is that a problem?"

It's Glimmer's turn to still, though the reassuring squeeze of Catra's hand around her fingers is emboldening.

"Adora. We live in *Soho*. Do you really think this would shock me?"

Glimmer almost seems disappointed, like she thinks Adora should have thought more of her. Adora doesn't say anything, but Catra does.

“I should go. You have to talk.”

Adora grasps at air as she reaches out for Catra, though she’s rewarded for her slowness by the vision of Catra's muscles twitching in the cold air before she pulls her clothes on. Both Glimmer and Adora stare at her - Catra smirks once she notices - and when Catra stretches her palm out to squeeze Adora's fingers goodbye, a wave of bravery floods through her. She pulls Catra close to her for a kiss, deepening it at the sound of Glimmer’s poorly-suppressed shriek of surprise.

Once Catra’s finally sauntered out the flat, her fingers gliding over every surface on her way, Glimmer jumps onto Adora’s bed and pins her in place.

“Fucking hell, Adora!” Glimmer shouts, completely oblivious to Adora’s discomfort trapped beneath her, “How can someone be that rude and that *hot*? And she’s sleeping with you?”

Adora splutters, unsure what part of her friend’s response to tackle first. “Y-you’re really okay with it?”

“Yes!” Glimmer says emphatically, “Do you think you’re the first dyke I’ve ever been friends with? It’s 1987!”

“Well, what other d-d…” Adora struggles to say the word, uncertain of its feel on her tongue. Before Glimmer, she’s only heard people say it in a nice (or neutral) way at the Waste, “...dykes do you know?”

Glimmer puts her hands on her hips, her eyes cast to the heavens as she runs a mental checklist. “There’s Spinny and Netossa-”

“I thought they were flatmates?” Adora questions.

Glimmer purses her lips, holding back laughter. “They share a bedroom, ‘Dor.”

“They could have been saving money! I didn’t want to assume, did I?”

"*Honey*."

Adora wilts under Glimmer's knowledgeable gaze. She feels like a bit of an idiot, and it reminds her of when she first moved to London and everything that surprised her seemed so obvious to everyone else. What else could she be missing?

"I've kissed girls before, you know," Glimmer says softly, "You could talk to me about her, or anyone else you've been with. If you wanted to."

"I don't think there's much to say," Adora fishes her pyjama top out from under the sheet and wriggles it over her head, "I wasn't like this in Wales. No one there is, they're just normal people."

"I doubt that's true, 'Dor. It must have changed things a bit, when people went over there to support the miners?"

"We're not miners," Adora tenses, "I'm from farmland. I told you that."

"Okay, I'm sorry. I didn't mean to…" Glimmer falters, and Adora doesn't recall seeing her so contrite and considered before, "I just want you to know I'll always be Team Adora. Alright? Whoever you're with."

"You can't tell anyone," Adora retorts, sitting up a little straighter, "Promise me you won't. Not your parents, not Bow."

Glimmer frowns but nods anyway, squeezing Adora's hand. "Does Catra tell people? About her, I mean?"

Adora considers it. She's not seen Catra in that many settings, and suddenly she feels like they don't know one another that well at all. "I don't think so. Not outside of the Crimson-" Adora interrupts herself. She's been so embedded in her new routine that she forgets the Waste isn't common knowledge. "The lesbian bar. She performs there."

"Performs?"

"She's a ballerina. But she does a different kind of dance there. Burlesque, I think?"

Glimmer blushes. "Wow. I'd like to see *that*."

"Glimmer!" Adora shoves at her friend, "I'm definitely not taking you now."

Glimmer shrugs, and her smirk reminds Adora of Catra for a second. It makes her look at her friend differently. Has Glimmer always suspected that she wasn't straight, even before she met Catra? It hadn't taken long for Catra to make assumptions, after all.

"Was it obvious?" Adora asks, her voice heavy with trepidation, "Am *I* obvious, I mean?"

Glimmer sighs, her eyes narrowing as she decides how to answer. "Not obvious, necessarily. But you never cared about any of the boys you went out with. And I always wondered if you just didn't trust us enough to say something."

"Of course I trust you!" Adora's throat is thick with emotion, tears gathering at the corners of her eyes, "I… I didn't know. I'd never wanted to kiss a woman until I met Catra. At least, I think. Maybe I'm just an idiot."

"You're not an idiot. You've got exceptional taste in friends," Glimmer reassures Adora, passing her a tissue from the bedside table, "And apparently, exceptional taste in women. Can you ask Catra where she got that lingerie set from? It's *really* nice."

Adora snorts, settling on the pillows. She's no idea if most people would react like Glimmer - she knows the neighbourly gossip back home has never been kind to any sort of sexual scandal - but a little part of her has somehow found relief. For now, it could be enough.

“Hey, Adora.”

Catra’s greeting bleeds warm and smooth through the receiver, and it makes Adora twirl her fingers in the spiral telephone cord like a lovestruck teenager. She’d called four times but this is the first time Catra has picked up.

“I can’t believe it actually works,” Adora marvels, imagining Catra’s cordless Motorola mobile phone, “There’s really no strings attached to it?”

She can practically hear Catra’s eyes rolling as she walks through the streets, the nighttime hubbub of Soho in the background, “No literal strings and no figurative strings, ‘Dor. I told you, this guy’s harmless. He’s just some philanthropist with cash to burn.” Her voice dips to a murmur, and Adora’s strains to hear over the crackling line, “I’m pretty sure he’s gay, alright?”

“Okay.” Adora replies, but she isn’t as assured as Catra is.

When she’d been told that the biggest donor funding Catra’s last ballet had sent her an exceedingly expensive mobile phone ahead of her upcoming tour, her first thought was that there had to be something underhand at play. But Catra’s much savvier than Adora is, and she can’t complain about being able to contact Catra wherever she is, especially now that her show rehearsals have started. As Catra’s schedule gets busier and busier, it’s impossible to ignore the fact that she’ll be gone from London in a few months.

“You’re quiet,” Catra says, “Can you still hear me?”

“Yes.”

“How about now?” Catra’s voice cuts through to Adora twice - it’s tinny in her ear but when she looks up, she can see Catra’s lips moving at the front of the shop. She’s wearing acid wash jeans over a tight leotard, and it dips low and round enough to see the

bruise Adora left at the top of her right breast. Catra hangs up her phone - it's even bigger than Adora remembered it was - and shoves it into her duffel bag.

Adora puts the receiver back on its dialler and watches Catra walk towards the counter, her eyes roaming over the other woman hungrily.

"Can I help you?"

"I don't know. Can you?" Catra bites her bottom lip and all Adora can think about is taking it between her own teeth, "I'm looking for something you might have in the back."

Adora scans the shop. There's only fifteen minutes to go until closing, and she's sure the stragglers browsing the Action titles will clear out soon. She leans forward over the counter to close the gap between them, her lips brushing Catra's ear. They can pass it off as a friendly kiss on the cheek if anyone looks their way, she's sure.

"I'll give you my key to the flat. If you wait upstairs and get changed, I'll come find you once I've locked up and we can go to the bar."

"Sounds good to me, princess."

Watching Catra's ass when she leaves is almost as good as watching her come into the shop.

"You're a filthy little lesbo, aren't you?" Adora's head snaps up to find one of the remaining customers advancing through the aisles, "What a waste, a pretty girl like you."

"Sir," Adora trembles as she projects her voice loudly so everyone can hear, wishing Catra hadn't just left, "I'm afraid you'll have to leave. It's closing time."

She checks who else is around, hoping they'll start to leave. The other customers are all men, also dressed in the same combo of

denim and leather. They're not Soho locals; they've got the frustration of folks in search of a different kind of video shop seeping from their pores. Usually, she can handle customers like this alright if she flirts a little - compliments them to send them on their way - but tonight it isn't going to work. She's outnumbered no matter what she does.

"Oh, we've got ourselves a Welsh lass, have we? You're far from the valley now, aren't you, blondie?"

Adora winces at the nickname. She's so used to being called 'blondie' at the Crimson Waste that it feels foreign in a man's mouth, its two syllables drenched in threat instead of sisterhood.

"Sir. I'm closing up. If you don't have a film you want to rent from us-"

"Funny," He's so close now that cheap cologne and cigarette smoke drift under her nostrils, "I'm sure I heard you say to your *friend* that we had fifteen minutes."

His fist clamps around Adora's wrist before she has any chance to react and he jerks her sideways, away from the protective barrier of the counter. Before she knows it, she's been pulled forward to the shop floor, her body forced flush against his.

"I bet you haven't had a real man before. A couple of nights with me would sort you right out."

Adora drives her knee into his groin as hard as she can, scrambling away when he lets go of her in surprise. Still, it doesn't stop one of his mates landing his own blow; she feels the sharpened impact of a fist on her left cheekbone long before she sees it coming. Adora shrieks, pain blooming across her face, and her yelp seems to catch the attention of others through the open shop door.

"Fuck, there's cops outside," she hears someone say, "Scram, this dirty dyke ain't worth the cell time."

It’s over as quickly as it began, and Adora rushes to lock the door the second after it slams shut behind them. Her hands tremble, fumbling with the lock, and the second she hears its final clink, Adora presses her back to the cold glass and sinks to the floor. Her cheek burns - her assailant must have been wearing a ring because she’s sure the skin’s split - and Adora knows her go-sees will be fucked for a week at least. Her head spins trying to process what just happened. She’s rooted to the spot for what feels like forever, praying that no-one else tries to come in.

“Adora?”

There’s a muffled sound from the outside. Her heart rate begins to race again. The letterbox is being forced open and she has to shuffle away to avoid it scraping the back of her neck.

“Adora?” Her chest heaves as she recognises Catra’s voice, though the concern she hears is foreign, “Is everything okay? It’s been nearly an hour.”

Adora reaches up to unlock the door and moves just enough for Catra to slip into the shop, shoving it shut again and turning the lock as soon as she’s in.

“Oh my God, ‘Dor,” Catra crouches in front of her instantly, taking Adora’s face in her hands and inspecting her broken skin, “What happened?”

“You should see the other guy,” she jokes weakly, though it doesn’t stop the tears from rolling down her cheeks. She's been naive for too long, “I should have been more careful.”

Catra’s lips press into a firm line, understanding sinking into her. Adora knows how cautious - how *scared* - Catra is, that she doesn’t wear pink triangle pin badges like Scorpia, or shave the underside of her hair like many of her friends at the Waste.

“I’d never let you get hurt, Catra. I promise.”

“Oh,” Catra chuckles softly, leaning forwards to kiss Adora gently, “You’re lovely when you take a stand. But I’d be much happier if you didn’t get another shiner.”

Adora lets Catra pull her to her feet and lock up the shop, and follows her up to the flat. She lies down on her bed and tries to ignore the hushed conversation drifting from the living room. The insults she’d received cycle over and over again in her mind, and an almighty wave of nausea crashes over Adora. She knew it would never be easy, but hopelessness scratches at her skin; she’ll never get to take Catra home to her parents, or kiss her at the back of the cinema, or wrap her arm around Catra’s waist so everyone in England knows who she belongs to.

There’s a clatter on the other side of the wall and some swearing, and then Catra appears in her room again with cotton balls and TCP in hand.

“Glimmer told me where to find the antiseptic,” Catra says, though Adora can’t shift her eyes away from the ceiling. “She’s worried about you, but I managed to fend her off for a bit.”

Catra perches on the edge of the bed and presses the cotton to the bottleneck of the TCP before tipping it upside down briefly and dabbing the stringent amber liquid over her cheekbone. Adora hisses and it sticks in her chest, stuttering through her lips in a sob.

“Shhh. I’ve got you, princess,” Catra’s voice is soothing, though her reassurance is misplaced, “You’ll book more gigs than Linda Evangelista once we’ve patched you up.”

Adora blinks, powerless to stop herself from speaking. “I’m going to fall in love with you and no-one will even know.”

“I’d know.” Catra puts the TCP and cotton down and gestures for Adora to sit up. She pulls the scrunchie out of her waves and scrapes blonde wisps back from Adora’s face, restoring the ponytail that has long fallen out. Adora makes a note to look for

her own scrunchie when she next goes down to the shop. The thought of it makes her shudder.

“Adora,” Catra starts, though there’s a pause before she finds the right words to continue, “It gets easier, living like this. And maybe one day, it’ll be different anyway. There’s loads of people at the Waste who go to protests and stuff. They’re adamant things can change.”

Adora searches Catra’s face for a lie. She only finds sadness, and a little bit of yearning.

“I don’t need government permission to love anyone,” Catra says eventually, “I won’t let my life be lesser for it, and neither should you.”

Warmth floods Adora’s veins. She remembers what Glimmer told her about Spinnerella and Netossa, and it’s easier to imagine sharing their own little flat with polaroids tacked to the wall. It’s a far cry from the sheep and fields she always assumed she’d return to. She reminds herself that her mother loves *Karma Chameleon* - it's comforting to hope that if she likes Boy George enough, she’d learn to like Catra too.

“I wish you weren’t leaving so soon.”

Catra smiles, her fingers locking between Adora’s own. “I’ve never much looked forward to coming home when I’m touring. It’ll be different this time. I’ll hardly wait.”

Adora wriggles into her seat, her eyes flicking nervously to her parents as they follow her to the centre of the row. It’s a miracle that Bryn and Carys Grey left the countryside at all, let alone that they came to London. But tonight is the final night of Catra’s European tour - she’s waited for seven months to welcome her

home - and Adora wants them to see Catra exactly the same way she does.

“I couldn’t believe it when you said your friend was a ballerina, cariad,” her mother says, her eyes wide as they sweep around the auditorium of the Covent Garden Opera House, “It’s a shock enough you started modelling.”

“Wait ‘til you see her dance, Mam,” Adora swells a little with premature pride, “It’s really something else.”

Catra doesn’t fail to deliver. It’s her first role as a soloist after years in the *corps de ballet*, and Adora’s listened to her stress over every tiny mistake so often on the phone that she feels her own body tense when the music swells ahead of the most difficult choreography. It’s unnecessary - the air seems to carry Catra effortlessly through her movements, and Adora has to restrain herself from cheering when the solo ends.

When they sit around the kitchen table the next day, squeezed into the cramped flat Adora has rented ahead of Catra’s return, it’s easy to pretend that this is a normal gathering. Her parents are effusive with their praise of the ballet - far more enthusiastic than they’ve been in response to Adora’s big break magazine ads - and Catra clutches Adora’s hand under the table.

“That expensive, is it?” Bryn says, peering into the singular bedroom once Adora’s pointed all the rooms out, “I don’t know why you can’t do your modelling whatsit from home, dwt. Not that I’d like to think about it, but if one of you’s got a gentleman caller, it’ll be a touch tricky.”

Adora gulps, catching Catra’s eye behind him. “We won’t have any gentleman callers, Da.”

“Don’t be prude on my account,” he laughs heartily, “I was a young man once!”

“No, Da. Mam,” Adora wrings her wrists nervously, “Me and Catra, we… She’s my caller. Gentlewoman caller, I suppose.”

“Oh.” Adora’s parents look at eachother, their faces blanched. Carys leans back in her chair, “It’s awful strange in London these days, isn’t it?”

Disappointment sinks in Adora’s gut, heavy and wide.

“It’s not just London, Carys. Aled Smith’s boy’s one of them too, apparently,” Bryn moves to placate Adora’s mother, his hand now resting on the back of her chair, “He had a couple too many beers at the Worker’s Club and told us the boy’s been getting up to all sorts in Cardiff.”

They all fall into silence. Awkwardness settles over them heavily; Adora has no idea what to do.

“Carys, Bryn,” Catra says eventually, her voice falsely confident, “I know I’m not what you expected for Adora. She’s not what my parents expected for me. But she’ll never be lonely or lacking on my watch. I love your daughter far more than any man could.”

“Well,” Carys says wearily after a beat, turning to face Adora, “Rhys Davies’ll be miffed when he hears you’re off the shelf. He had even less of a chance with you than we thought.”

“You don’t have to tell anyone,” Adora hurries to say, “I’d understand, you know, if you weren’t comfortable. But I didn’t want to lie to you anymore.”

“Pshh. All they play in the Worker’s Club is Boy George and God knows who else,” her mother replies, her eyes flicking over Catra, “And she’s a lot prettier than Rhys.”

“She’s lush, she is,” Bryn replies mindlessly, earning himself an elbow in the ribs from his wife.

Adora crawls into bed - *their bed* - and straddles Catra, pinning her hands above her head and dipping down to kiss her lips. Catra's already put the stereo on quietly, and the k.d. lang cassette Perfuma lent Catra for her Walkman on tour fills the space between them. It's the first time they've really had any privacy since they got home, and Adora wants to touch Catra so much it almost hurts.

"How are you feeling?" Catra asks, her eyes roaming Adora's face, "That could have gone a lot worse."

"I was sure it would," Adora whispers, "But you said you loved me, so-"

"What?" Catra blushes as she interrupts Adora, rose red spreading across her cheeks "I didn't."

"Yes, you did. You told Mam you did, anyway," Adora teases Catra, watching how her freckles fade a little into her reddened skin, "Unless it was just for dramatic effect?"

"It wasn't," Catra gulps slowly, and Adora watches her throat bob, "For dramatic effect, I mean."

It's impossible for Adora not to smile. She moves her hands away from Catra's wrists and cups her jaw instead. "If I said I loved you, it wouldn't be for dramatic effect either. Just so you know."

"Good to know," Catra replies.

"Because I really do love you," Adora clarifies, "Even more than Sigourney."

"You're such an idiot," Catra laughs, "I love you more than Sigourney too."

Adora Grey didn't think she'd find herself in an underground lesbian bar at the age of twenty-three, but it's April 1990 and that's exactly where she is.

Now that Adora's even more of a regular at the Crimson Waste than Catra used to be, no-one calls Catra by her stage name anymore. It's apparently unusual - two femmes without a butch in sight - but Adora wouldn't trade anything for the feel of Catra's long hair running through her fingers. Still, she doesn't mind watching Kitty please the crowd with a dance (even if she'd rather Glimmer didn't have that blown-eyed look on her face when Adora begrudgingly lets her tag along).

Adora's a little more recognisable too, especially since she landed a country-wide Maybelline campaign. It won't be long until they can afford to find a place a little bigger to rent. Somewhere with room for all their friends to gather: a table big enough for Glimmer and Bow, and Scorpia and Perfuma, and anyone else who adds to their little family that's building.

She wears a thin metal band on her finger - the same one that Catra has - and it might not mean anything officially, but it's enough for anyone who needs to know. When Kitty finishes performing, Catra always finds Adora in the same seat at the bar and leads her up the stairs to the stars.

No matter how late it gets, it's always Adora's favourite when Catra walks her through the night.

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I'd love to hear what you thought :)

UPDATE: Part 2 with Catra's POV now posted ❤️

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!